Danilo Symonette

Ph.D. Student, Computer Science Department
Stanford University

dlonzell@stanford.edu
linkedin.com/in/danilo-symonette-6a3076174

Research Interests

Human–Computer Interaction (HCI), AI for Learning, Generative Simulations, Multimodal Interfaces, Learner Agency

Education

2022–present **Stanford University**
Ph.D. in Computer Science
Advisor: Prof. James Landay

May 2020 **University of Maryland, Baltimore County**
B.S. in Computer Science

May 2017 **College of Southern Maryland**
A.S. in Computer Science

Research Experience

Aug 2022–present **Stanford University**
Graduate Researcher, Stanford HCI Group

Tools for learner-authored simulations *(with Jane L. E, James Landay, Parastoo Abtahi, Roy Pea)*
Built GELLI, a Vision Pro app combining AI-generated scenarios, dialogue, and imagery with language support and reflection. A within-subjects study (N = 40) found greater immediate vocabulary recall and confidence than matched videos; qualitative analysis (N = 43) examined learner agency, imaginative immersion, and exploration.

Presence and learning in classroom VR *(with Cyan DeVeaux, Jeremy Bailenson)*
Investigating classroom VR through interviews, observations, and a 62-student comparison of group versus solo 360° video experiences. Quantitative analysis and manuscript development are ongoing.

Jun–Aug 2019 **Massachusetts Institute of Technology**
Summer Research Assistant, Teaching Systems Lab
Trained support vector machines and CART decision trees to detect struggle and confusion in Teacher Moments simulations from speech and transcript features. Engineered prosodic and linguistic features using Python audio-analysis tools, LightSide, and IBM Watson; coauthored work on cognitive dissonance and mixed emotions in teacher learning.

Jan 2018–Aug 2020 **University of Maryland, Baltimore County**
Undergraduate Research Assistant, AVAIL Lab
Built a data crawler and API integrations to collect student-team conversations from Slack and GroupMe.
Applied support vector machines, regression trees, and statistical analysis to conversational and psycholinguistic features, studying team performance and student self-assessments.

Work Experience

Aug 2020–Aug 2022 **Johns Hopkins University Applied Physics Laboratory**
Associate Staff I, Research and Exploratory Development
Designed CIRCUIT's 2021 online training curriculum, an AI and data-science resource library, and an interface for personalized training plans based on individual skill assessments.
Taught Python, data science, and AI to CIRCUIT interns; developed prototypes for on-demand training and interactive visualization of technical concepts.
Conducted a study comparing accuracy and workload in neuroimaging-data labeling using a desktop interface and immersive VR; contributed to Precision Learning proposals and program development.

Publications

[1] **Danilo Symonette**, Alan Y. Cheng, Taiga Ikedo, Jose Manuel Rosales Juarez, Roy Pea, Parastoo Abtahi, Jane L. E, James Landay. "GELLI: A Generator for Experiential Language Learning Interactions." ***In submission.***

[2] Rohan Ahuja, Daniyal Khan, **Danilo Symonette**, Shimei Pan, Simon Stacey, Don Engel. "Towards the Automatic Assessment of Student Teamwork." In: *GROUP 2020 Companion*, 2020, pp. 143–146. DOI

[3] G. Hillaire, M. Thompson, R. Slama, **Danilo Symonette**, J. Reich. "Analyzing the Relationship Between Cognitive Dissonance and Mixed Emotion to Support Emotion Regulation in Teachers." In: *American Educational Research Association Annual Meeting*, 2020.

[4] Rohan Ahuja, Daniyal Khan, **Danilo Symonette**, Marie desJardins, Simon Stacey, Don Engel. "A Digital Dashboard for Supporting Online Student Teamwork." In: *CSCW 2019 Companion*, 2019, pp. 132–136. DOI

Honors and Awards

Feb 2025–Feb 2026 **Learning through Creation with Generative AI**
Stanford Accelerator for Learning — $50,000 in project funding for "Language Learning Through the Creation of Immersive Role Play Simulations," with James Landay.

2020 **NSF Graduate Research Fellowship**

Last updated: October 21, 2026